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Before You Try to Go Deep

If you're so far inside the scared kid that even deciding what to do next feels impossible, don't turn “go deeper” into another job you have to perform. Get some support around you first. Come back when there's enough adult you available to make a choice and stick with it.

You Don't Need an Inner Monologue

If you're reading all this thinking, “But I don't have a voice in my head,” that's fine. When I say ask the child something, I don't mean you have to literally hear an answer. Maybe words come by themselves; maybe you have to make them on purpose. If the inside of your head stays quiet, ask out loud or write the question down. And if that still isn't how your mind works, maybe a drawing, a picture or song, a sensation or urge, or simply doing something caring is enough. You don't have to replace missing words with vivid pictures, either. Sometimes the mind is simply quiet. That doesn't mean you're resisting anything.

Sometimes the feeling lands first; other times the words do, and sometimes you can't tell. Leave it that way until words would actually help you figure out what happened or what to do. Thinking about it later isn't automatically avoidance, and feeling first doesn't settle what the feeling means.

Regulation May Come Before Dialogue

And sometimes words aren't the problem at all; your body is just too charged.

If your solar plexus, abdomen, or somewhere else feels clenched and it's hard to relax into that heart-chakra love, try a slower, non-forced exhale or some gentle massage. I love using one foot to massage the other like a Yin/Yang symbol. Circular or spiral massage over the tense area can be nice too.

Sometimes you need more bottom-up help than that: Shaking, tapping (Emotional Freedom Technique), EMDR, Brainspotting, Somatic Experiencing, Water Therapy, Massage, Energy Healing, or another approach that works from the body upward.

The order matters here; sometimes you have to get the body down a notch before talking works.

If imagery starts carrying you away from the room you're actually sitting in, open your eyes. Look at the room, know what time it is, feel your body here. If a session leaves you more disoriented, more compelled, or functioning worse afterward, make it shorter next time—or stop and get grounded support.





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